PEW RESEARCH CENTER
JANUARY 26-29, 2012
FINAL TOPLINE
N=1,006

ASK ALL:

PEW.1 As I read a list of some stories covered by news organizations this past week, please tell me if you happened to follow each news story very closely, fairly closely, not too closely, or not at all closely. First, **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE;] [IF NECESSARY** "Did you follow **[ITEM]** very closely, fairly closely, not too closely or not at all closely?"**]**

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a. Reports about the condition of the U.S. economy					
January 26-29, 2012	35	31	16	19	*
January 19-22, 2012	35	30	16	19	1
January 12-15, 2012	33	32	14	20	1
January 5-8, 2012	39	31	15	15	*
December 15-18, 2011	36	32	14	16	1
December 8-11, 2011	41	29	13	16	1
December 1-4, 2011	40	33	13	13	1
November 17-20, 2011	35	33	16	15	1
November 10-13, 2011	39	31	15	14	*
November 3-6, 2011	37	31	15	17	1
October 27-30, 2011	38	33	14	15	1
October 20-23, 2011	38	32	14	16	1
October 13-16, 2011	39	32	14	14	*
October 6-9, 2011	43	28	14	14	1
September 29-October 2, 2011	46	26	14	14	*
September 22-25, 2011	44	33	11	11	*
September 8-11, 2011	40	30	15	14	1
September 1-4, 2011	44	30	11	15	*
August 25-28, 2011	44	28	14	13	1
August 18-21, 2011	44	29	12	14	1
August 4-7, 2011	46	30	11	13	1
July 28-31, 2011	43	30	13	13	*
July 21-24, 2011	41	32	13	13	1
July 14-17, 2011	41	30	14	14	1
July 7-10, 2011	36	30	15	18	1
June 30-July 3, 2011	38	32	13	16	1
June 23-26, 2011	37	29	15	19	*
June 16-19, 2011	39	33	14	13	*
June 9-12, 2011	39	30	15	16	1
June 2-5, 2011	35	34	17	14	*
May 19-22, 2011	33	34	17	16	*
May 12-15, 2011	32	32	17	18	2
May 5-8, 2011	40	35	15	9	1
April 21-25, 2011	41	33	12	14	*
April 14-17, 2011	44	30	14	12	1
April 7-10, 2011	46	30	14	10	*
March 31-April 3, 2011	42	31	16	11	0
March 24-27, 2011	36	32	17	15	*
March 17-20, 2011	38	32	17	13	*
March 10-13, 2011	40	30	16	13	*
March 3-6, 2011	37	31	17	13	1
February 24-27, 2011	49	29	11	10	*
February 17-20, 2011	35	33	14	17	*
February 10-13, 2011	36	34	13	16	*
February 3-6, 2011	35	37	14	14	*
January 20-23, 2011	37	33	14	15	1
January 13-16, 2011	37	29	15	18	1

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
January 6-9, 2011	39	37	11	12	1

SEE TRENDS FOR PREVIOUS YEARS: http://www.people-press.org/files/2011/11/NII-Economy-Trends.pdf

b. Barack Obama's State of the Union speech					
January 26-29, 2012	29	18	16	37	1
January 27-30, 2011	28	22	13	36	1
January 29-February 1, 2010	33	22	17	29	1
TREND FOR COMPARISON:					
February 27-March 2, 2009: *Barack Obama's first address to a joint session of Congress*	37	26	14	23	*
February 1-4, 2008: *President Bush's State of the Union address*	18	17	20	45	*
January 26-29, 2007: *Reports about George Bush's State of the Union address*	25	26	20	28	1
February, 2006: *George W. Bush's State of the Union address*	24	22	19	34	1
February, 2003	36	24	15	24	1
January, 1994: *Reports about Bill Clinton's State of the Union address*	26	25	18	31	*
February, 1992: *President Bush's State of the Union Address*	26	26	20	27	1
c. Google announcing new policies about how to track people's web use					
January 26-29, 2012	7	15	24	53	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
August 18-21, 2011: *Google buying Motorola's cell phone business*	7	12	17	64	1
March 26-29, 2010: *Google's decision to stop using computer servers in China to avoid government censorship*	9	16	25	49	1
January 15-18, 2010: *Google announcing that it may leave China*	6	16	21	57	1
d. U.S. special forces rescuing aid workers in Somalia					
January 26-29, 2012	21	22	23	33	1
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
May 5-8, 2011: *The killing of Osama bin Laden in a raid by American forces*	50	30	13	6	1
July 3-7, 2008: *The rescue of 15 hostages held by rebels in Colombia*	17	27	23	32	1
April 5-9, 2007: *Fifteen British sailors and marines held captive and later releases by the Iranian government*	31	37	18	14	*
March 30-April 2, 2007: *Fifteen British sailors and marines held captive by the Iranian government*	27	28	22	22	1
November, 1990: *The plight of American hostages and other Westerners detained in Iraq and Kuwait*	49	33	13	4	1
October, 1990	47	37	11	5	*
September, 1990	57	30	9	3	1
e. Historically low interest rates for banks and home mortgages					
January 26-29, 2012	16	21	24	38	2

PEW.1 CONTINUED…

	Very closely	Fairly closely	Not too closely	Not at all closely	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
TRENDS FOR COMPARISON:					
January, 1992: *The Federal Reserve Bank's interest rate reduction*	35	31	19	14	1
May, 1990: *Reports about renewed inflation and rising interest rates*	18	29	26	26	1
f. News about candidates for the 2012 presidential elections					
January 26-29, 2012	28	30	21	21	1
January 19-22, 2012	28	30	17	24	*
January 12-15, 2012	29	29	18	23	1
January 5-8, 2012	29	30	16	25	*
December 15-18, 2011	26	24	20	29	1
December 8-11, 2011	27	27	18	28	*
December 1-4, 2011	25	28	20	26	1
November 17-20, 2011	24	31	21	23	1
November 3-6, 2011	22	31	20	26	1
October 27-30, 2011	21	26	21	30	1
October 20-23, 2011	21	28	22	28	1
October 13-16, 2011	26	29	22	23	1
October 6-9, 2011	25	25	23	27	1
September 29-October 2, 2011	27	26	21	25	*
September 22-25, 2011	25	26	23	25	1
September 15-18, 2011	24	28	21	27	1
September 8-11, 2011	22	26	21	31	*
September 1-4, 2011	22	23	22	32	1
August 25-28, 2011	22	22	22	33	1
August 18-21, 2011	27	26	19	28	1
August 11-14, 2011	19	24	20	36	1
August 4-7, 2011	18	21	22	37	1
July 28-31, 2011	17	27	21	35	1
July 21-24, 2011	17	22	28	32	*
July 14-17, 2011	18	26	27	28	1
July 7-10, 2011	16	23	27	33	1
June 30-July 3, 2011	21	28	24	25	2
June 23-26, 2011	19	26	24	31	*
June 16-19, 2011	23	29	23	25	*
June 9-12, 2011	18	30	22	30	1
June 2-5, 2011	21	31	22	26	*
May 26-29, 2011	20	27	24	28	*
May 19-22, 2011	15	27	24	32	1
May 12-15, 2011	15	22	26	35	1
May 5-8, 2011	16	24	27	32	1
April 21-25, 2011	18	26	23	32	1
April 14-17, 2011	20	23	29	27	1
March 24-27, 2011	13	19	26	41	1
March 10-13, 2011	15	21	26	38	0
February 10-13, 2011	16	19	24	40	*
February 3-6, 2011	15	20	23	42	*

SEE TRENDS FOR PREVIOUS YEARS: http://www.people-press.org/files/2011/11/NII-Election-Trends.pdf

ASK ALL:

PEW.2 Which ONE of the stories I just mentioned have you followed most closely, or is there another story you've been following MORE closely? **[DO NOT READ LIST. ACCEPT ONLY ONE RESPONSE.]**

Jan 26-29 2012	
22	News about candidates for the 2012 presidential elections
18	Barack Obama's State of the Union speech
15	Reports about the condition of the U.S. economy
6	U.S. special forces rescuing aid workers in Somalia
4	Historically low interest rates for banks and home mortgages
2	Google announcing new policies about how it tracks people's web use
10	Some other story **(VOL.)**
23	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**

ASK ALL:

PEWWP.1 Just in general, how well do you think **[INSERT ITEM; RANDOMIZE]** understands the problems of average Americans? How about, [**INSERT NEXT ITEM; RANDOMIZE]**?[1]

	Very well	Fairly well	Not too well	Not at all well	**(VOL.)** DK/Ref
a. Barack Obama					
January 26-29, 2012	28	26	17	23	7
b. Mitt Romney					
January 26-29, 2012	7	29	23	23	18
c. Newt Gingrich					
January 26-29, 2012	10	22	22	27	18

ASK ALL:

PEW.3 Overall, what's your impression of the candidates running for the REPUBLICAN presidential nomination? AS A GROUP, would you say they are excellent candidates, good candidates, only fair candidates or poor candidates?

BASED ON REGISTERED VOTERS [N=784]:

						SELECTED TRENDS FOR COMPARISON[2]:						
						Oct 2007		Sep 2003	Oct 1995	Oct 1991	Jan 1988	
Jan 26-29 2012		Jan 4-8 2012	Nov 9-14 2011	Aug 17-21 2011	May 25-30 2011	Rep cands	Dem cands	Dem cands	Rep cands	Dem cands	Rep cands	Dem cands
4	Excellent	3	5	4	3	3	9	3	3	2	4	2
21	Good	27	23	22	22	28	35	29	30	19	36	29
37	Only fair	35	36	38	35	40	33	39	44	39	41	44
34	Poor	27	28	26	27	19	17	15	19	16	11	17
5	DK/Ref. **(VOL.)**	7	7	9	13	10	6	14	4	24	8	8

1 PEWWP.1a-c asked in conjunction with *The Washington Post*.

2 Before October 2007, answer choice read "Fair" not "Only Fair." In October 2007 the question was asked both ways and no difference was found. As a result, October 2007 numbers combine both versions of the question. In 1988, 1991 and 1993 question asked about "men running for the [party] presidential nomination."

PEW.3 FULL TREND:

Overall, what's your impression of the candidates running for the REPUBLICAN presidential nomination? AS A GROUP, would you say they are excellent candidates, good candidates, only fair candidates or poor candidates?

BASED ON REPUBLICAN AND REPUBLICAN-LEANING REGISTERED VOTERS [N=341]:

	Excellent	Good	Only fair	Poor	(VOL.) DK/Ref
Jan 26-29, 2012	8	38	40	12	2
Jan 4-8, 2012	5	46	34	10	6
Nov 9-14, 2011	10	38	39	7	6
Aug 17-21, 2011	9	40	38	6	7
May 25-30, 2011	5	39	36	7	13
February, 2008	10	50	31	7	2
January, 2008	11	57	28	3	1
November, 2007	9	47	34	7	3
October, 2007	5	46	36	7	6
September, 2007	8	41	36	8	6
October, 1995	5	46	40	6	3
January, 1988 *(GP)*	6	50	35	4	5

Overall, what's your impression of the candidates running for the DEMOCRATIC presidential nomination? AS A GROUP, would you say they are excellent candidates, good candidates, only fair candidates or poor candidates?

BASED ON DEMOCRATIC AND DEMOCRATIC-LEANING REGISTERED VOTERS:

	Excellent	Good	Only fair	Poor	(VOL.) DK/Ref
February, 2008	30	50	16	2	2
January, 2008	28	50	18	2	2
November, 2007	16	51	28	2	3
October, 2007	16	48	26	5	5
September, 2007	15	49	29	2	5
January, 2004	8	39	41	6	8
December, 2003	5	40	39	7	9
September, 2003	4	40	39	5	12
February, 1992	6	39	47	4	5
October, 1991	3	24	38	11	23
January, 1988 *(GP)*	4	33	45	11	7

ASK ALL:

PEW.4 Regardless of whom you might prefer, which Republican candidate have you heard the most about in the news recently? **[READ NAMES; RANDOMIZE]**

Jan 26-29
2012

42	Newt Gingrich
36	Mitt Romney
4	Ron Paul
2	Rick Santorum
1	Other **(VOL.)**
15	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**

PEW.4 FULL TREND:

Thinking about Republican candidates for president in 2012… Regardless of whom you might prefer, which Republican candidate have you heard the most about in the news recently? ***[OPEN END. RECORD FIRST MENTION ONLY.] [PLEASE BE CERTAIN TO DISTINGUISH BETWEEN "JOHN MCCAIN" AND "HERMAN CAIN".]***

	Jan 12-15 2012	Jan 5-8 2012	Dec 1-4 2011	Oct 13-16 2011	Sep 8-11 2011	Aug 18-21 2011	Jul 21-24 2011	Jun 16-19 2011	Jun 2-5 2011	May 12-15 2011	Apr 14-17 2011
Newt Gingrich	6	11	13	*	1	1	1	5	2	12	1
Mitt Romney	51	39	5	18	12	7	13	27	22	7	9
Ron Paul	4	6	1	1	2	3	1	1	1	2	*
Rick Santorum	1	9	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*
Rick Perry	2	3	3	12	31	22	3	*	*	*	*
Herman Cain	1	*	43	23	*	1	*	*	*	*	*
Michele Bachmann	*	3	*	1	7	23	23	5	1	1	*
Jon Huntsman	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*
Gary Johnson	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*	*
Other											
None/DK/Ref.	32	26	32	39	37	35	44	45	41	50	53

ASK ALL:

PEW.5 Did you happen to watch President Obama's State of the Union address on Tuesday night, or didn't you get a chance to see it?

			TREND FOR COMPARISON:
Jan 26-29		Jan 27-30	Jan 29-Feb 1	President Obama's speech about health care
2012		2011	2010	Sep 11-14, 2009
42	Yes, watched	40	45	41
58	No, didn't watch	59	55	59
*	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**	*	1	*

IF DIDN'T WATCH OR DON'T KNOW (PEW.5=2,9) READ:

From what you've read and heard about the speech…

ASK ALL:

PEW.6 Overall, did you have a positive or negative reaction to President Obama's State of the Union address?

Jan 26-29 2012	
42	Positive
27	Negative
13	Neither/Neutral **(VOL.)**
17	Don't know/Refused **(VOL.)**